

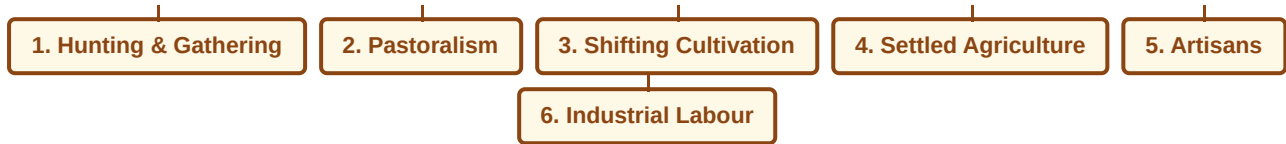
TRIBAL INDIA — Part 1

Occupational & Linguistic Classifications

Sarrthi IAS | Anthropology Optional Paper 2 | UPSC CSE 2026

SECTION 1: Occupational (Economic) Classifications of Tribes

Tribal Economy — 6 Types



- Economic life of tribes varies from **gathering to settled agriculture**
- Each tribe has a **distinctive economy** but also practices subsidiary occupations
- Progression: Gathering → Pastoralism → Shifting Cultivation → Settled Agriculture → Industrial Labour

1. Hunting & Gathering

- **Foraging** = searching for food in nature (fruits, nuts, animals, fish) by gathering, fishing, or hunting
- Oldest economic system — since appearance of *Homo sapiens*
- Food gatherers = **0.004% of world population**; in India: mainly **south India & Andaman Islands**

Characteristics of Hunting & Gathering Economy

Simple technology	Digging stick, basket, bows & arrows, spears, boomerangs
Nomadism	Nomadic and semi-nomadic lifestyle
Low population density	Tribe rarely exceeds few thousand; bands of 25–30
Self-sufficient unit	Small nomadic band or semi-nomadic settlement
Division of labour	Men: hunting; Women: food collection
No surplus	No surplus, no trade

📖 **Marshall Sahlins** — termed hunting-gathering societies the "*original affluent society*" — affluence = satisfaction through balance with nature, not material accumulation.

Sustainability Features

- Limited extraction & seasonal rotation of resource zones
- Ritual taboos on hunting during breeding seasons
- Collective ownership & sharing norms prevent hoarding
- Deep ecological knowledge via oral traditions, songs, myths

Case Studies

Chenchu

Nallamala Hills, Andhra Pradesh & Telangana

- Depend on forest foods, honey, roots, small game
- Seasonal foraging cycles; deep ecological knowledge
- Hunting restrictions during breeding seasons; collective sharing

Yanadi

Nellore & Chittoor, AP/Tamil Nadu

- Skilled fisherfolk; bamboo traps, hand-woven nets
- Men fish & hunt; women gather fruits, roots, herbs
- Remarkable knowledge of tides, fish migration, wetland ecology

Onge

Little Andaman Island

- Negrito tribe; hunting, gathering, fishing
- Diet: fish, turtle, pig, honey, yams
- Egalitarian sharing norms; ritual restrictions on overharvesting

Jarawa

Andaman Islands

- Hunter-gatherers along coastal & forest belts
- Wild pigs, fish, honey, tubers, fruits
- Group sharing; ritual purification before hunts

Kadar

Anamalai & Nelliampathy Hills, Kerala

- Skilled collectors of honey, wax, forest produce
- Known for knowledge of elephant trails and herbs
- Subsistence combines foraging + seasonal wage work

2. Pastoralism

- Transitional phase between food collection and food production
- Subsistence via **domestication of animals** in areas not suitable for agriculture
- Pastoralists move herds seeking grazing land; exchange products with neighbouring agriculturalists

Features of Pastoral Economy

Small population	Move place to place for animal food
Domestication	Only occupation where rainfall insufficient for agriculture
Semi-nomadism	Constant movement for grazing
Transhumance	Part of population moves seasonally; others remain at home

Tribe	Animal	Location
Toda	Buffaloes	Nilgiris, Tamil Nadu
Gujjar	Sheep	J&K, Himachal
Bhotia	Yak, sheep	Uttarakhand

Case Study: Nilgiri Hills — Traditional Interdependence Model

Group	Role	Exchange Function
Toda	Pastoralists (sacred buffalo)	Produce milk, curd, ghee → trade for grains & crafts
Kota	Artisans & blacksmiths	Pottery, metal tools, carpentry; ritual musicians at Toda ceremonies
Irula	Hunters & gatherers	Trapping, snake catching, pest control; supply forest produce
Badaga	Agriculturalists	Grains & vegetables; hire Irulas & Kurumbas as labourers
Kurumba	Forest collectors & medicine-men	Honey, wax, herbs; shamanic healing for other groups

- **Exchange:** Barter (dairy for grains/crafts), ritual ties (Kota musicians, Kurumba priests), reciprocity
- **Sacred dairies** managed by Toda priests — only ritually pure men may enter
- **Modern changes:** Tea plantations → monetisation; Todas supply milk to Aavin cooperatives; NGOs revive Toda embroidery & Kota pottery
- **Significance:** Self-regulating, multi-ethnic economy; each group's livelihood complements others

3. Shifting Cultivation

- Practiced on **hill slopes**; dates back to **Neolithic times** (8,000–10,000 years ago)
- Also known as: **Jhum** (NE India), **Bewar** (Baiga), **Podu**, **Kumri**
- Tribes: Gonds, Baiga, Kukis, Maler



Nadeem Hasnain — Shifting cultivation dates back to Neolithic times (8,000–10,000 years ago); transition from nomadic to settled life.

Process (6 Steps)

1. Select plot → cut plants and trees
2. Dry and burn to ashes
3. Till soil with digging stick or hoe
4. Sow seeds of different crops at monsoon onset
5. Harvest in winter
6. Leave plot to fallow → move to new plot

Sustainability Dimension	Key Point
Ecological Balance	Fallow regeneration; soil restoration; forest regrowth; mixed cropping
Social Regulation	Community-owned land; collective decision-making; prevents conflict
Cultural Integration	Rituals before clearing; post-harvest ceremonies; gratitude to nature
Gender & Labour	Men clear & burn; women sow & weed — balanced division

Challenges

- Government restrictions on burning shorten fallow cycles, reducing fertility
- Monocropping & cash crops disturb ecological balance
- FAO (2019): traditional shifting cultivation **can be sustainable** if customary laws & long fallows maintained

Case Studies

Maler (Paharia)
Rajmahal Hills, Jharkhand

- Small-scale rotational shifting cultivation on forested hill slopes
- Crops: millets, pulses, maize, cucurbits, roots
- Ritual offering to deities before cutting; taboos on clearing near springs/sacred groves
- ICAR: traditional jhum more ecologically stable than commercial monocropping

Baiga
Maikal Hills, MP & Chhattisgarh

- **Bewar cultivation** — burning dry vegetation, sowing mixed crops on hill slopes
- Felling fruit-bearing trees (mahua, mango, tamarind) strictly prohibited
- Sacred groves preserved for ritual & biodiversity
- Reflects **Nature-Man-Spirit Complex** (Vidyarthi, 1963)

📖 **Vidyarthi (1963)** — *Nature-Man-Spirit Complex*: economic activity, ecology, and belief form an integrated system among tribal communities.

4. Settled Agriculture

- Involves ploughing, draught animals, fertilisation, irrigation, weeding, crop rotation
- Enables **permanent cultivation of fields**; unit of production = **family**
- Surplus production exchanged for goods/services
- Tribes: Santhals, Mundas, Oraons, Gonds, Baiga

Feature	Detail
Settled life	Permanent rural and urban settlement
High population density	Highest among all economic types
Complex technology	Ploughing, irrigation, land parcels
Division of labour	Based on age and sex
Land ownership	Private / hereditary
Political leadership	Full-time — village headman, councils

Case Studies

Santhals

Chotanagpur Plateau — Jharkhand, West Bengal, Odisha, Bihar

- One of the **largest tribal groups** in India
 - Settled plough cultivation; monsoon rain-fed
 - Crops: rice, millets, pulses, maize, oilseeds
 - Use manure, crop rotation, fallow systems
 - Land: hereditary, patrilineal
- Reciprocal labour exchange: **parma**
 - Village headman: **Manjhi**
 - Deity: **Marang Buru** (Great Mountain Spirit)
 - Festivals: **Sohrai** (cattle/fertility), **Baha** (agricultural cycle)

 **N.K. Bose** — Santhal agriculture represents a bridge between subsistence economy and market participation.

Apatani — Rice-Fish Cultivation

Ziro Valley, Lower Subansiri District, Arunachal Pradesh

- **Integrated rice-fish farming** — most sophisticated indigenous practice in NE India
 - Terraced paddy fields with bamboo irrigation channels
 - Common carp introduced after rice transplantation
- Fish eat insects/weeds (pest control); waste = natural fertiliser
 - Community collectively manages irrigation
 - FAO: **GIAHS** (Globally Important Agricultural Heritage Systems)

Comparison	Santhals	Apatanis
System	Subsistence → settled plough	Advanced integrated rice-fish farming
Key Feature	Market transition + <i>parma</i>	Ecological harmony + GIAHS recognition
Common Thread	Traditional ecological knowledge + community cooperation	

5. Tribal Artisans

- Handicrafts as **subsidiary occupation** — combining traditional skill with economic need
- Preserve rich tribal art forms; provide additional income

Craft	Tribes
Basket Making (Bamboo)	Bhils, Santhals, Nagas
Tool Making (Iron & Wood)	Agarias, Lohars
Spinning & Weaving	Gonds, Kotas, Apatanis
Pottery	Kumbhars, Santhals

 **TRIFED** (est. 1987, Min. of Tribal Affairs) — promotes tribal handicrafts via **TRIBES India** outlets. Key schemes: **Van Dhan Yojana** & **MSP for MFP** (Minor Forest Produce).

Case Studies

Asur (PVTG)

Gumla & Latehar, Jharkhand; also Chhattisgarh, Bihar

- One of **earliest iron-smelting communities** in India
- Primitive bloomery furnace: clay furnaces, animal-skin bellows, charcoal fuel
- Produced sickles, ploughshares, knives, arrowheads from lateritic iron
- Declined due to industrial steel plants (Tata, Bokaro) & forest restrictions
- Mythical ancestor: *Asura Raja*; festivals: **Sarhul & Karma**

Agaria

MP, Chhattisgarh, UP, Jharkhand

- Sub-group of Gonds; name from *agar* = furnace
- Pit furnaces lined with clay & stone; hand-operated bamboo bellows
- Produced hoes, ploughs, sickles, weapons, ornaments
- Smelting villages formed **industrial clusters** — early division of labour
- Now: agriculture, daily labour; some continue via TRIFED/Van Dhan

6. Agriculture & Industrial Labourers

- Significant tribal population shifted to **agricultural & industrial labour** due to historical/economic pressures
- Many tribes became **landless labourers** — wages in cash, kind, or crop share
- **Colonial policies** led to large-scale **land alienation** and forced displacement
- Examples: **Santhals** and **Oraons** of eastern India lost land, now depend on wage labour
- Many engage in **seasonal migration** for manual/industrial work during lean agricultural seasons

SECTION 2: Linguistic Classification of Tribes

India has over **700 tribal groups**, each with its own distinct language or dialect. Tribal languages belong to **4 main linguistic families**:

4 Linguistic Families of Indian Tribes

1. Austro-Asiatic

2. Tibeto-Chinese (Sino-Tibetan)

3. Dravidian

4. Indo-European

Language Family	Tribes	Location	Antiquity
Dravidian	Gondi, Kurukh, Kui	Central & South India	4,000+ years (Krishnamurti, 2003)
Austro-Asiatic (Munda)	Santhali, Mundari, Kharia	Eastern & Central India	One of earliest in South Asia (Anderson, 2008)
Tibeto-Burman	Bodo, Naga, Lepcha	Northeast India	Affinities with E & SE Asia
Indo-Aryan Tribal	Hajong, Bhili	NE & West India	Layers of contact & assimilation

1. Austro-Asiatic Family

- Over **150 languages**, **100 million+ speakers** across SE Asia & South Asia
- In India: primarily **eastern & central regions**
- Unique feature: system of **phonetic tones** distinguishes it from other families

Origin — Scholar Debate

 **W. Schmidt** — Named the Munda language as Austro-Asiatic.

 **Heine Geldern** (1928) — Mongoloid people entered India from NE side, brought Munda languages which spread to middle India.

 **Hutton** — Austro-Asiatic brought by Kolarians through west Himalayas; Mon-Khmer speakers from east Himalayas.

 **Suniti Kumar Chatterji** — Certain nouns in Hindi, Punjabi, Bengali borrowed from Munda languages.

Two Branches in India

Branch	Languages	Location
Mon-Khmer	Khasi, Nicobari	Meghalaya; Nicobar Islands
Munda	Santhali, Kherwari, Ho, Mundari, Gondi, Kharia, Savara, Khond, Gadaba	Eastern & Central India (Jharkhand, WB, Odisha, Bihar)

2. Tibeto-Chinese (Sino-Tibetan) Family

- Subfamily of larger Sino-Tibetan family; includes languages of China, India, SE Asia
- Divided into: **Siamese-Chinese** & **Tibeto-Burman**

(a) Siamese-Chinese Sub-family — Tai Group

Tribe	Location	Key Facts
Tai-Khampti	Namsai, Arunachal Pradesh	Khampti = "land full of gold"; Theravada (Hinayana) Buddhists
Tai Phake (Phakial)	Assam (~2,000 people)	Migrated from Thailand in late 18th century

(b) Tibeto-Burman Sub-family — 4 Branches

Branch	Languages / Tribes
Tibeto-Himalayan	Bhotia (Darjeeling); Chamba, Lahauli, Swangli, Kanauri
Non-Pronominalized Himalayan	Rong/Lepcha, Toto (West Bengal)
Arunachal	Aka/Hrusso, Abor, Miri, Dafla

Assam-Burmese	Bara/Bodo: Kachari, Dimasa, Garo, Tripura Naga: Angami, Ao, Sema, Rengma; Naga-Bodo: Kachcha Naga, Kabui Naga Kachin: Singpho Kuki-Chin: Manipuri, Thado, Sokte, Ralte, Lushai
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3. Dravidian Family

- **250 million speakers**; predominantly southern India, SW Pakistan, NE Sri Lanka
 - Earliest evidence: **2nd century BCE** — Tamil-Brahmi script (Madurai & Tirunelveli caves)
- 📖🖋️ **Robert Caldwell** (1856) — Published *Comparative Grammar of the Dravidian or South-Indian Family of Languages* — established Dravidian as a major world language family.

📖 **Krishnamurti (2003)** — Dravidian languages trace back at least **4,000 years**, predating Indo-Aryan expansion.

Language	% Speakers	Language	% Speakers
Telugu	34.5%	Gondi	1.2%
Tamil	29.0%	Brahui	0.9%
Kannada	15.4%	Kurukh	0.8%
Malayalam	14.4%	Tulu	0.7%

- **Dravidian-speaking STs:** Kurukh (Eastern India), Gondi (Central India)
- **Outside India:** Brahui (Balochistan, Pakistan); Dhangar/Kurukh dialect (Nepal, Bhutan, Bangladesh)
- Tamil numerals influenced numerals of other Dravidian languages

4. Indo-European Family

- Proto-Indo-European homeland: **Pontic-Caspian Steppe** (modern Ukraine/S. Russia/Kazakhstan), c. 4000–3000 BCE
- **Kurgan Hypothesis** by Marija Gimbutas
- Expansion: Westward (Celtic, Germanic, Italic, Hellenic) + SE into South Asia (Indo-Iranian → Indo-Aryan & Iranian)

Tribal Example	Branch	Location	Key Features
Hajong	Eastern Indo-Aryan	Meghalaya, Assam, Arunachal Pradesh	Indo-Aryan dialect + Tibeto-Burman influence; mixed Hindu-animistic practices; festivals: Chorkhela, Pusne
Bhili	Western Indo-Aryan	Rajasthan, MP, Gujarat, Maharashtra	Bhili dialects show Dravidian & Munda influences — centuries of contact

- 📖 **Morris Swadesh (1950s)** — Proposed **Glottochronology** — estimates language divergence based on rate of loss of shared core vocabulary. Indo-Iranian split from PIE: c. 2000–1800 BCE.

📖 **Colin Masica (1991)** — Indo-Aryan languages eventually became the majority tongue of the subcontinent.

📖 **Abbi (2017)** — Survival of Austro-Asiatic & Tibeto-Burman languages demonstrates deep antiquity and diversity of tribal linguistic heritage.

Endangered Languages

- India: **19,500+ languages/dialects**; **2nd largest number of endangered languages** globally
- UNESCO: **197 endangered** including **42 critically endangered**
- 1961 Census: 1,652 languages → PLSI (2010): only 780 documented
- India has 68 living scripts; newspapers in 35 languages; AIR broadcasts in 120 languages
- Only **4% of India's languages** represented in Parliament
- Highest diversity: Arunachal Pradesh, Assam, Odisha, West Bengal, Maharashtra, Gujarat, Rajasthan

Critically Endangered Examples

Language	Tribe	Location	Status
Majhi	—	Sikkim	Only 4 speakers (one family)
Birhor	Birhor	Central India	Critically endangered (~2,000 speakers)
Asur	Asur	Jharkhand	UNESCO endangered
Korwa	Korwa	Jharkhand	UNESCO endangered
Koro	—	Arunachal Pradesh	Endangered
Dimasa	—	Assam	Endangered

Reasons for Endangerment

- Dominance of major regional languages (Hindi, Bengali, Tamil) in government & education
- Loss of traditional knowledge among speakers
- Youth migration to urban areas; adopt modern lifestyles
- Loss of **intergenerational transmission**

Government Initiatives

Initiative	Details
CIIL (est. 1969, Mysore)	Central Institute of Indian Languages — documentation & preservation
PLSI (2010)	People's Linguistic Survey of India
SPPEL	Protection of Endangered Languages; CIIL documents mother tongues with <10,000 speakers; Phase 1: 117 languages on priority
MLE Programme (Odisha, 2006)	3,385 tribal language teachers; dictionaries for 20 tribal languages
MTBMLE (KISS, Odisha)	Kalinga Institute teaches 10 tribal dialects; bridges home-school language gap
Eighth Schedule push (2018)	Odisha proposed inclusion of Ho, Mundari, Bhumji
Community Radios	Asur tribe (Jharkhand) uses radio for music, poetry, native language revitalisation

Key Strategies

- Documentation and archiving of languages
- Promoting bilingual education & language revitalisation programmes
- Recognising rights of linguistic minorities
- Community-driven initiatives (radios, oral documentation)

QUICK REVISION CHEAT SHEET

One-page rapid recall for all Part 1 topics

Topic / Subtopic	Key Scholars	Key Case Studies	Trigger Keywords
Hunting & Gathering	Marshall Sahlins ("original affluent society")	Chenchu (AP), Yanadi (AP/TN), Onge (Little Andaman), Jarawa (Andaman), Kadar (Kerala)	Foraging, nomadism, 0.004%, band, no surplus, egalitarian
Pastoralism	—	Toda (buffalo, Nilgiris), Nilgiri Model (Toda-Kota-Irula-Badaga-Kurumba), Gujar, Bhotia	Transhumance, domestication, barter, sacred dairy, Aavin
Shifting Cultivation	📌 Nadeem Hasnain (Neolithic origin); Vidyarthi (Nature-Man-Spirit Complex)	Maler/Paharia (Jharkhand), Baiga (MP — Bewar)	Jhum, Bewar, Podu, fallow, slash-burn, hill slopes, mixed cropping
Settled Agriculture	📌 N.K. Bose (Santhal bridge); FAO/GIAHS (Apatani)	Santhals (<i>parma</i> , Manjhi, Sohrai, Baha); Apatani (rice-fish, Ziro Valley)	Plough, surplus, Marang, Buru, rice-fish, GIAHS, <i>parma</i>
Tribal Artisans	TRIFED (1987); Van Dhan Yojana	Asur (PVTG, iron smelting, Jharkhand); Agaria (sub-Gond, pit furnace)	Bloomery, <i>agar</i> , iron smelting, Sarhul, Karma, TRIBES India
Industrial Labour	—	Santhals, Oraons (eastern India — landless)	Land alienation, colonial policies, seasonal migration, wage labour
Austro-Asiatic Family	📌 W. Schmidt (naming); 📌 Heine Geldern (NE entry); 📌 Hutton (Kolarian route); 📌 S.K. Chatterji (borrowings)	Munda branch: Santhali, Ho, Mundari; Mon-Khmer: Khasi, Nicobari	Phonetic tones, Kolarians, Mon-Khmer, Munda
Tibeto-Chinese Family	—	Tai-Khampti (Namsai, gold, Theravada); Tai Phake (Assam); Bodo-Naga-Kuki-Chin groups	Sino-Tibetan, Tibeto-Burman, Siamese-Chinese, Namsai, Lepcha/Toto
Dravidian Family	📌 Robert Caldwell (1856 grammar); Krishnamurti (4,000 yrs)	Gondi (Central India), Kurukh (Eastern India), Brahui (Pakistan)	250M speakers, Tamil-Brahmi 2nd cent BCE, Telugu 34.5%
Indo-European Family	Marija Gimbutas (Kurgan); Morris Swadesh (Glottochronology); Colin Masica (1991)	Hajong (Meghalaya, mixed Hindu-animist); Bhili (Rajasthan — Dravidian/Munda influence)	Pontic-Caspian Steppe, PIE, Kurgan, Glottochronology, 1500 BCE
Endangered Languages	Abbi (2017, deep antiquity); UNESCO	Majhi (4 speakers, Sikkim), Birhor, Asur, Korwa, Koro	197 endangered, 42 critical, CIIL, SPPEL, PLSI, MLE, KISS, 8th Schedule

Source: Sarrthi IAS — Thor × Team Avengers Handout 2 | Nataraj Sir | Compiled for UPSC CSE 2026